VIT Bhopal University

VITyarthi E-Learning Platform

CSE0001 – Digital Literacy

Project Report – Digital Literacy Portfolio

Field	Details
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Introduction

This project report documents my work on the CSE0001 Digital Literacy portfolio assignment at VIT Bhopal University. For this project, I have taken on the role of a Student Digital Ambassador — a student responsible for helping peers navigate the digital world safely and effectively.

The portfolio consists of five tasks, each mapped to one module of the course. Over the course of this project, I have created a digital awareness infographic, set up professional profiles on key platforms, explored coding and collaboration tools, practised professional email communication, and researched cybercrime threats relevant to Indian college students. All deliverables are organised in a public GitHub repository, which itself forms part of the submission.

No prior coding experience was required or assumed. Every tool used in this project is free and accessible through a web browser. The goal of this project is not just academic submission, but the building of a genuine digital foundation that will support my education and career over the coming years.

Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

What I Made

For Task 1, I created a one-page digital literacy awareness infographic using Canva (canva.com), a free browser-based graphic design platform. The infographic is titled 'Digital Literacy: Your Superpower in the Digital Age' and is designed to be visually engaging for a first-year college student audience.

The infographic covers three key topic areas. The first section defines digital literacy as the ability to find, evaluate, create, and communicate information using digital technology — framing it as an essential skill rather than an optional extra. The second section covers safe internet practices, using icons and short bullet points to communicate tips such as using strong passwords, recognising phishing links, and enabling two-factor authentication. The third section focuses on professional online presence, encouraging students to create a LinkedIn profile, maintain a clean GitHub portfolio, and think carefully about what they post on social media.

Tool Used

Canva was chosen for this task because it requires no design experience, offers hundreds of free templates, and produces professional-quality output. I selected an 'Education Infographic' template as a base and customised the layout, colours, text, and icons.

Reflection

The most challenging aspect of this task was deciding what to leave out. Digital literacy is a broad topic, and fitting three meaningful sections into a single page required editing down content significantly. What I found most interesting was discovering how much free, professional-quality design software is available online — I had assumed that creating polished visual content required expensive tools like Adobe Illustrator. Canva demonstrated that design accessibility has improved dramatically. This task also reminded me that how information is presented is as important as the information itself; the same content as a wall of text would be far less likely to be read or remembered.

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Platforms Set Up

For Task 2, I set up professional profiles on three platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. Screenshots of all three profiles have been added to the task-2-portfolio/screenshots/ folder in my GitHub repository.

Platform Descriptions

GitHub (github.com)

GitHub is the world's leading platform for version control and collaborative software development. It uses Git, a system that tracks changes in code over time. I created a profile README — a special repository named after my username — containing my name, branch, year, and a statement about what I hope to learn. GitHub will serve as my primary code portfolio throughout my degree.

LinkedIn (linkedin.com)

LinkedIn is the world's largest professional networking platform. It is used by recruiters, companies, and professionals across all industries to connect, share opportunities, and build professional reputations. I filled in my Education section with my current degree, institution, and expected graduation year. Over the next four years, I intend to add internship experience, project descriptions, certifications, and skills.

Kaggle (kaggle.com)

Kaggle is a community platform for data scientists and machine learning practitioners. It hosts publicly available datasets, competitions with real-world problems, and learning courses. I chose Kaggle because I am interested in exploring data science as a specialisation during my B.Tech.

Future Plans

Over the next four years, I plan to use GitHub to host all my coding projects and assignments, making my skills visible to future employers. I will use LinkedIn to network with alumni, apply for internships from third year, and build industry connections. Kaggle will be the platform where I practise data analysis and machine learning skills beyond the classroom curriculum.

Task 3 – Coding & Collaboration Platforms

Part A – Coding Practice (HackerRank)

For the coding practice component, I created an account on HackerRank (hackerrank.com) and completed the 'Solve Me First' challenge — a beginner-level problem designed to familiarise new users with the platform's code editor, input/output format, and submission system. The problem required writing a function that takes two integers and returns their sum, which I implemented in Python. A screenshot of the accepted submission is in the task-3-platforms/ folder.

HackerRank is widely used by technology companies as part of their hiring process. Familiarity with the platform will be essential when I begin applying for internships and placements.

Part B – Google Workspace (Google Forms)

I built a five-question Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz using Google Forms. The quiz is designed to test the knowledge of my batchmates on topics covered in this course. The questions include:

- What does the term 'Digital Literacy' refer to? (Multiple Choice)
- Which of the following is a safe internet practice? (Multiple Choice)
- What should you do if you receive a suspicious email asking for bank details? (Multiple Choice)
- Name one platform you would use to build a professional portfolio online. (Short Answer)
- What is two-factor authentication (2FA) and why is it important? (Short Answer)

The form is linked to a Google Sheet so that all responses are automatically recorded and can be analysed. The form link is in the README and the screenshots are in the task-3-platforms/ folder.

These tools will be directly useful in my academic life. HackerRank gives me a structured environment to practice problem-solving and competitive programming. Google Forms will be useful for group project surveys, peer feedback, and event registrations. Together, they represent two ends of the digital skills spectrum — technical coding ability and collaborative communication — both of which are essential for any technology professional.

Task 4 – Professional Email Etiquette

Communication Scenario

Poor digital communication has caused real professional harm in many documented cases. One relevant scenario involves a university student who, frustrated with a delayed grade, sent an angry, informal email to a professor using slang, no greeting, and an accusatory tone. The professor forwarded the email to the department head, and the student received a formal warning. The situation could have been handled very differently: a polite, structured email acknowledging that the student understood the professor was busy, clearly stating the concern, and requesting a meeting would likely have resolved the issue constructively. The tone, structure, and word choice in professional digital communication directly determine outcomes.

Key Learnings

This task reinforced that professional email communication is a learnable skill with clear rules. The most important rules I identified are: always include a clear, specific subject line; use a formal greeting (Dear Professor / Dear Mr./Ms.); state your purpose in the first sentence; keep the body concise and organised; and close with a formal sign-off followed by your full name and contact details.

The Social Media Do's and Don'ts checklist in the task-4-email-etiquette/ folder extends these principles to social media. The key insight is that every piece of digital communication — whether an email, a tweet, or a WhatsApp message to a group — leaves a record and contributes to your digital reputation.

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness

Case Study: UPI/Online Payment Fraud

For Task 5, I researched UPI/Online Payment Fraud — a type of cybercrime that is particularly prevalent among young adults and first-time digital payment users in India. My case study, available in full in the task-5-cybercrime/casestudy.md file, describes how fraudsters use a fake 'wrong transfer' story to trick victims into approving a Collect Request on their UPI app — which deducts money rather than receiving it. The case study covers the step-by-step process, typical victims, and consequences.

What Surprised Me

While researching this topic, the detail that surprised me most was how technically simple this fraud is. There is no hacking, no malware, and no special technical skill involved — just psychological manipulation. The fraudster exploits a genuine feature of UPI (the Collect Request) by creating confusion about how it works. This highlights that cybercrime is not just a technical problem; it is also a psychological one. Being aware of these tactics is the most effective defence.

One Habit I Will Change

As a result of this research, I will personally change one habit: I will never enter my UPI PIN without first reading the full transaction detail shown on screen — specifically confirming whether the action is 'Send' or 'Collect', and verifying the registered name of the recipient or requester. I will also share the prevention checklist I created with family members who use digital payment apps.

Conclusion

This project has been a comprehensive introduction to digital literacy as a practical, applied skill. Across five tasks, I have moved from understanding concepts (what digital literacy means) to taking real actions (creating profiles, writing emails, completing coding challenges, and researching cybercrime). The most valuable outcome of this project is not any individual deliverable, but the combination: a GitHub repository that is now the beginning of a real professional portfolio. The skills and platforms I engaged with in this project — GitHub, LinkedIn, HackerRank, Google Workspace, and awareness of cybercrime — are the same ones I will use throughout my four years at VIT Bhopal and in my career beyond.

References

- Canva – Free graphic design tool: https://canva.com
- GitHub – Version control and code hosting: https://github.com
- LinkedIn – Professional networking platform: https://linkedin.com
- Kaggle – Data science community platform: https://kaggle.com
- HackerRank – Coding practice platform: https://hackerrank.com
- Google Forms – Survey and quiz tool: https://forms.google.com
- National Cyber Crime Portal, Government of India: https://cybercrime.gov.in
- National Cyber Crime Helpline: 1930 (24x7)
- VIT Bhopal University VITyarthi Portal: https://vityarthi.vitbhopal.ac.in